

pointed for identifying the cases of false caste-based reservations and to take action against the guilty. Even Chief Minister Narendra Modi's government started cancelling the ST certificates of fake tribals in 2001. Now there are 200 such cases of government employees alone that are pending before the Vigilance Officer of Godhra district.

However, the committee has taken action in some cases while ignoring the "powerful". The state government too seems to be in no hurry to withdraw the ST status of all such people and is taking sporadic action which often appears selective. But, even though they may be wrong, arbitrary action has led to simmering anger which threatens to erupt into a caste war in Panchmahal district. Ujamabhai Padaria, 62, of Shiyal village is a non-tribal on paper,

and his son—who got a teacher's job on the basis of an ST certificate—has recently been termed a non-ST and is on the verge of losing his job. Pulling out a list of five dozen government servants from his village who got jobs based on ST certificates, an agitated Padaria says: "Why single us out? Just because we are poor? There are many top officers against whom complaints were received but no action was taken. If the government can prove that we are wrong then it should take action against all and cancel the ST certificates of all."

Laxman Bhima Khant, 60, a poor farmer of Dholighati village whose schoolteacher son too is facing similar action breaks down while narrating his story. "We are victims of politics. Thousands of Khants (an OBC Kshatriya surname) have secured jobs as STs so why are we being victimised," he says. When asked as to why he is a non-

tribal and his son a tribal, he shoots back: "My father was ignorant about tribal rights despite being a tribal. He committed a mistake by writing, 'Hindu Khant' instead of 'Hindu Bhil' (Hindu tribal) against his name. Why should we pay the price for it?"

Almost everybody in possession of a fake tribal certificate uses the same defence. Bhathibhai K. Khant of village Nanirel, whose daughter was rusticated from college for having secured admission on a false ST certificate in 1997 insists: "We are paying the price for our elders' ignorance. We are tribals." Pratap K Pagi, 57, of Nanirel village works as a patwari and is an OBC on government records but his two sons are STs and have taken the related benefits. His elder son Rajesh got admission in an ayurvedic college and eventually became a doctor while his younger son managed to get a teacher's job on an ST status. Says Pagi: "Our elders were illiterate and backward. They didn't know the meaning of ST and failed to register themselves as tribals in school and government records. We were enlightened and therefore registered our children as tribals. There is no dichotomy in this."

Now, some of them have started talking in a militant tone. Amit Padaria, vice-president of the Kadana district panchayat and a vocal BJP leader who had contested the 2002 panchayat election on a reserved tribal seat, says: "If we have progressed somewhat, is it our fault? Should we move around in knickers and dhotis in order to look like impoverished tribals? If the government dares withdraw the tribal status for us, a bloody situation, like that of the violent Gujar agitation, might crop up." Shankarbhai Khant, a farmer from Golanpur village says: "We will fight for our rights till the end. We will not put up with injustice. How can we be labelled non-tribals after having been considered tribals for so long?"

But tribals do not agree. Gangjibhai G. Parghi of village Khedapa on the Gujarat-Rajasthan border says: "The government should immediately step in to protect the privileges of tribals against usurpation by non-tribals. A reason why this fraud has flourished is because we genuine tribals do not have powerful leaders who can protect our

▼ PRATAP KUBER PAGI (right) and RAJESH PAGI, VILLAGE NANIREL, SANTRAMPUR

Pagi (57), who works as a patwari, is an OBC while his two sons are tribals and have garnered related benefits. Elder son Rajesh, 35, using an ST certificate, got admission in an ayurvedic college and later became a doctor while the younger one is a teacher.

